

Below is a **complete, exam-oriented explanation of Chapter 1 ("The Historian and His Facts") of E. H. Carr – *What is History?***. I've structured it by arguments, examples, and conclusions exactly as Carr develops them, and I reference the chapter throughout (from your PDF).

Chapter 1: The Historian and His Facts – Complete Explanation

1. Why Carr asks “What is history?”

Carr begins by showing that even famous historians disagree on what history is.

Two opposite views:

Lord Acton (1890s):

- Believed history could become “*ultimate history*”.
- Thought all facts could eventually be known.
- History = objective collection of true facts.
- The historian’s job: record them accurately.

Sir George Clark (1950s):

- Said history is always rewritten.
- Knowledge comes through human minds → processed, biased.
- No final, absolute history.
- Doubts complete objectivity.

Carr’s point:

Our definition of history depends on our time and society.

So asking “What is history?” is not trivial—it reflects how we understand society itself.

2. The 19th-century “cult of facts”

Carr describes how historians in the 19th century believed:

- Facts are sacred.
- Opinions are separate.
- Historians should not interpret, only record.

Leopold von Ranke’s slogan:

History should show “how it really was.”

Positivists added:

First collect facts → then draw conclusions.

British empiricism supported this:

- Subject (historian) and object (facts) are separate.
- Facts exist independently.

Carr calls this the “**commonsense view**”:

Facts are like fish on a slab. The historian just picks them up and cooks them.

Acton wanted history written so neutrally that no one could tell which author wrote which part.

Carr strongly rejects this idea.

3. What is a “historical fact”?

Carr’s key argument:

Not all facts about the past are historical facts.

Example:

- Battle of Hastings in 1066 → historical fact.
- What you ate yesterday → fact, but not historical.

Why?

Because **historians choose** what matters.

Accuracy is necessary, but not the essence of history.

He quotes:

“Accuracy is a duty, not a virtue.”

Basic facts (dates, places, inscriptions) are raw material, not history itself.

The crucial idea:

Facts do not speak for themselves. The historian calls on them.

The historian decides:

- Which facts matter
- In what order
- In what context

So:

A historical fact = a past event **selected and interpreted by historians**.

4. How facts become “historical”: the Stalybridge example

Carr gives a concrete example:

In 1850:

- A gingerbread seller was beaten to death by a mob at Stalybridge.

For years:

- No historian mentioned it → not a historical fact.

Later:

- Dr. Kitson Clark cites it in a lecture.

Now:

- It is *proposed* as a historical fact.

Whether it becomes accepted depends on:

- Whether historians find it meaningful for understanding Victorian society.

So:

A fact becomes historical only when historians find significance in it.

Interpretation creates historical facts.

5. Survival of facts is biased

Ancient Greece example:

We know mainly:

- Athenian views.

We don't know:

- Spartan
- Persian
- Slave perspectives

Why?

Because:

- Athenian writers preserved their own views.

So history is shaped by:

- Who wrote
- What they believed
- What they chose to preserve

Middle Ages example:

We think medieval people were deeply religious because:

- Most records were written by churchmen.

Other aspects of life were ignored or lost.

Carr quotes:

| History is “a series of accepted judgements.”

So history is not a neutral mirror of the past.

6. The modern historian’s problem: too many facts

Ancient historians:

- Have few sources → natural selection of facts.

Modern historians:

- Have too many sources.

They must:

- Select what is significant.
- Reject most data.

Carr criticizes:

- Dry factual histories
- Over-specialized monographs
- Knowing “more and more about less and less”

He argues Acton failed as a historian because he waited for *perfect facts*.

Conclusion:

| History is not collecting maximum facts. It is selecting meaningful ones.

7. The fetish of documents (Stresemann example)

Carr attacks blind faith in documents.

Case study:

German foreign minister Stresemann left 300 boxes of papers.

Bernhard (his secretary):

- Selected documents to glorify his western policy.
- Minimized Soviet relations.

Later:

- English translator Sutton cut more material.

Result:

- Western readers got a distorted picture.

Even worse:

- Diplomatic records show only what Stresemann claimed happened.

If Soviet records existed, they’d tell another story.

Conclusion:

| Documents tell us what someone thought happened—not what truly happened.

Facts require interpretation.

8. Why old historians avoided philosophy of history

19th century:

- Confident
- Believed in progress
- Thought meaning was obvious

They didn’t ask “What is history?”

After World War I:

- Confidence collapsed
- Philosophers challenged factual objectivity

Croce said:

| “All history is contemporary history.”

Meaning:

- We see the past through present problems.

Carl Becker said:

█ Facts exist only when historians create them.

Collingwood argued:

- History = re-thinking past thoughts in the historian's mind.
- Facts depend on interpretation.

9. Studying the historian, not just the facts

Carr says:

When reading history, first study the historian.

Example: G. M. Trevelyan was a Whig historian.

His interpretation of Queen Anne reflects Whig beliefs.

Facts are like fish in the sea:

- Historian chooses:
 - Where to fish
 - What tools
 - What fish he wants

So:

█ History = interpretation.

10. Dangers of extreme subjectivity

If everything depends on the historian:

- No objective truth exists
- Any interpretation is valid

Carr rejects this.

Interpretation varies, but:

█ Some interpretations are better than others.

He warns against:

- Propaganda history
- Soviet / anti-Soviet distortions
- Twisting facts for political purposes

11. How historians actually work

Carr explains the real method:

Not:

1. Read all sources
2. Then write

But:

- Read → write → read more → revise → reinterpret → repeat

Interpretation and facts develop together.

Two dangers:

- Only facts → meaningless chronicle
- Only interpretation → fiction/propaganda

Good history balances both.

12. Final definition of history (very important for exams)

Carr's famous conclusion:

History is a continuous process of interaction between the historian and his facts, an unending dialogue between the present and the past.

This is the central thesis of Chapter 1.

One-page exam memory summary

You can memorize this:

- Facts ≠ history
 - Historian selects facts
 - Documents are biased
 - History = interpretation + facts
 - Past is seen through present
 - Avoid pure objectivism and pure subjectivism
 - History = dialogue between past and present
-

Below is a **complete, exam-oriented explanation of Chapter 2 – “Society and the Individual”** from E. H. Carr's *What Is History?*, structured exactly around Carr's arguments and examples. I also cite the chapter wherever key claims or formulations come directly from the text.

Chapter 2 – Society and the Individual (Complete Explanation)

1. The “hen and egg” problem: which comes first?

Carr opens with the question:

Does society come first, or the individual?

His answer:

- The question is wrongly framed.
- Society and the individual are **inseparable and complementary**, not opposites.

He quotes:

- John Donne: *“No man is an island.”*
- J. S. Mill: people do not change substance when brought together.

But Carr says Mill is mistaken to assume individuals exist first and society later. From birth:

- Humans are shaped by society.
- Language is social.
- Thinking is socially formed.
- Ideas come from others.

Hence:

An individual outside society would be “speechless and mindless.”

The Robinson Crusoe myth fails because Crusoe is still socially formed (English, Christian, brings his Bible, creates society again with Friday). Suicide (Kirilov in Dostoyevsky) is the only purely individual act; all other acts involve society.

2. Individualisation grows with society (not against it)

Anthropologists say primitive man is more socially moulded than modern man.

Carr partially agrees:

- Simple societies → uniform roles.
- Modern societies → many occupations → greater individuality.

But:

Individualisation and social development grow together.

A complex society = strong **interdependence** between individuals.

Modern nations shape thought just as powerfully as tribes.

“Human nature” itself varies by country and century → it is **historical**, not fixed.

Differences between Americans, Russians, Indians arise mainly from social organisation.

Conclusion:

You cannot have the hen without the egg or the egg without the hen.

3. The modern “cult of the individual”

Carr explains why people wrongly oppose society and individual:

- Renaissance → birth of individualism (Burckhardt).
- Linked to:
 - Capitalism
 - Protestantism
 - Industrial Revolution
 - Laissez-faire
 - French Revolution (“rights of man”)
 - Utilitarianism

This ideology made **individual initiative** central.

But Carr insists:

This was a social process, not an escape from society.

It reflected a stage of historical development.

Now:

- Mass democracy
- Collective economic organisation

Yet old ideology remains strong in the West.

Modern debates about “liberty vs equality” are really:

struggles between social groups, not individuals vs society.

Abstract individualism today is a political slogan that blocks understanding.

He rejects treating the individual as a tool of the state, but also rejects the idea of an individual outside society.

4. History is not written by isolated individuals

The 19th-century view:

History = individuals writing about individuals.

Carr says this is superficial.

Because:

- Knowledge is socially accumulated.
- Historical actors acted within societies.
- History = interaction between historian and facts (from Chapter 1).

Now he reframes the problem:

How far is the historian shaped by society? How far are historical facts social facts?

The historian:

- Is an individual
- But also a **product and spokesman of his society**

He introduces the metaphor:

History is a “moving procession”.

The historian is not above it, but **inside it**. His position in the procession determines what he sees.

Thus:

The historian is part of history.

5. Historians mirror their societies (Grote & Mommsen)

Carr shows how historians’ social positions shape their histories.

Grote (History of Greece)

- Radical banker (1840s England)

- Idealised Athenian democracy
- Neglected slavery → reflected English middle-class blindness to factory workers

Mommsen (History of Rome)

- German liberal after 1848 revolution failed
- Wanted a “strong man” to save Germany
- Idealised Caesar
- Depicted Cicero as weak

Carr argues:

These histories tell as much about their own times as about ancient history.

Great history happens when:

insight into the present illuminates the past.

Mommsen never wrote the history of the Roman Empire because Germany had not yet produced its “strong man”.

6. Namier: conservatism as historical viewpoint

Sir Lewis Namier:

- True conservative after WWI
- Chose:
 - English politics before ideological revolutions
 - European revolution of 1848 (failure of liberalism)

He called 1848:

“The revolution of the intellectuals.”

Namier disliked political ideas influencing politics.

Carr’s purpose:

To show that historians must be understood through their social standpoint.

The historian, Carr says:

“is the product of history.”

7. Historians change with history (Meinecke & Butterfield)

Meinecke (German historian)

Three phases:

1. 1907 – nationalism as universal good
2. 1925 – conflict between morality and state
3. 1936 – despair under Nazism
4. 1946 – history ruled by blind chance

Carr says:

He reflects successive historical periods.

Butterfield

1931:

- Condemned Whig interpretation.
- Said studying past using present is “unhistorical”.

1944:

- Praised “marriage of present and past”.
- Defended Whig tradition.

Carr concludes:

The historian is in flux because society is in flux.

Always check:

- Author
- Date of writing

Two books cannot truly be written by the same historian.

8. Whole schools of history reflect society

19th-century Britain:

- History = progress.

After WWI:

- Decline
- Toynbee → cyclical history
- Others → “no pattern in history”

Carr says:

▮ This is not individual thinking, but social change.

Quote:

▮ “There is no more significant pointer to the character of a society than the kind of history it writes.”

Acton hoped history would free us from present bias.

Carr replies:

▮ Only historians conscious of their social position can transcend it.

Key rule:

▮ Before studying the historian, study his social environment.

9. Are historical facts about individuals or social forces?

Carr attacks what he calls:

▮ “The Bad King John theory of history”

= History explained by character of individuals.

Examples:

- Greeks → heroes
- Renaissance → Plutarch
- Victorian Britain → “great men”
- Wedgwood → history about how men *felt*

Carr rejects:

- Separating individual from society
- Explaining history through conscious motives alone

Individuals are **members of groups by definition**.

Biography ≠ history.

History = inquiry into:

▮ “the past of man in society.”

10. Conscious motives are insufficient

People do not fully know why they act.

History cannot rely on:

▮ “why they thought they acted”.

Carr rejects mystical forces, but quotes Marx:

▮ “History does nothing... man does everything.”

Two empirical facts:

(1) Numbers matter

French Revolution:

- Caused by hunger of millions, not philosophers.

Lenin:

▮ “Politics begin where there are millions.”

Masses are individuals acting together → social force.

One peasant doesn't matter; millions do.

(2) Results differ from intentions

Many thinkers agree:

- Adam Smith – invisible hand
- Hegel – cunning of reason
- Marx – relations independent of will
- Tolstoy – men are unconscious instruments
- Butterfield – history twists intentions

World wars and depression were not intended by anyone.

Therefore:

| History is about social relations and unintended outcomes of actions.

11. Rebels are social products

Rebels are not “individuals vs society”.

Wat Tyler, Pugachev, Nietzsche:

- All products of their societies.
- Important only because they express social forces.

Same with “great men”.

12. The role of great men

Carr rejects:

- Great men as creators outside history
- Also rejects: great men are meaningless

Correct view:

| Great men are products and agents of social forces.

Hegel:

| The great man expresses the will of his age.

Some shape forces (Lenin, Cromwell), others ride them (Napoleon, Bismarck).

13. Final conclusion (exam critical)

Carr's definition:

| History is a social process.

Both:

- the historian
- the historical facts

are social.

Society today ↔ society yesterday.

Burckhardt:

| “History is the record of what one age finds worthy of note in another.”

Final function of history:

| To understand past society and gain mastery over present society.

Ultra-compact exam memory sheet

You can memorize:

- Individual & society inseparable
- Individual shaped by society
- Individualism = historical ideology
- Historian = product of society
- Historians mirror their times
- Facts = social facts
- Numbers matter
- Outcomes ≠ intentions
- Rebels & great men = social phenomena
- History = dialogue between societies, not isolated individuals

Below is a **complete, exam-oriented explanation of Chapter 3 – “History, Science, and Morality”** from E. H. Carr’s *What Is History?*, structured exactly around Carr’s arguments, examples, and conclusions. Key claims are cited directly from your attached chapter.

Chapter 3 – History, Science, and Morality (Complete Explanation)

1. Is history a science?

Carr begins with the old debate: **“Is history a science?”**

- In most European languages, *science* includes history.
- In English, history is often separated from science.

In the 18th–19th centuries:

- Science succeeded spectacularly → people tried to apply scientific methods to society and history.
- Society was first seen as a **machine** (Newtonian model).
- Later, after Darwin, as an **organism** evolving over time.

Darwin’s importance:

Science became concerned not with timeless facts, but with **process, change, and development**.

So history and science both began to focus on **change**, not static laws.

2. The old idea of “laws” in science – and why it collapsed

Earlier scientists believed:

- Nature is governed by fixed laws (Newton, Boyle, etc.).
- Scientists discover laws by induction from facts.
- Social thinkers copied this:
 - “Law of population” (Malthus)
 - “Iron law of wages” (Lassalle)
 - Marx’s “economic law of motion of modern society”

Buckle even claimed history followed **“universal and undeviating regularity.”**

But modern science changed:

Henri Poincaré showed:

- Scientific laws are really **hypotheses**
- Tools to organize thinking
- Always provisional and revisable

Modern view:

Science progresses by a circular (better: reciprocal) process between facts and theories.

So:

- No final laws
 - Only working hypotheses that help understanding
-

3. History uses hypotheses just like science

Carr says historians work exactly the same way.

Examples:

(a) Weber's thesis

Protestantism → capitalism Not a law, but a **fruitful hypothesis** that deepened understanding.

(b) Marx's example

“The hand-mill gives feudal society; the steam-mill gives industrial capitalism.”

Again: not a law, but a guiding hypothesis.

Without hypotheses:

- Historians drown in facts (Sombart's “ocean of facts”).

Periodization

Dividing history into:

- Ancient / Medieval / Modern

This is:

- Not a fact
- A hypothesis useful for interpretation

Same with:

- “European history”
- Whether Russia is European

These choices reveal the historian's **bias**.

Carr quotes Georges Sorel:

Historians must use partial, provisional hypotheses and keep correcting them.

4. History and science use the same method

Both:

- Select facts through theories
- Test theories using facts
- Advance by successive approximations

Carr notes:

A historian called history:

“a series of accepted judgements”

A physicist defined scientific truth as:

“what experts publicly accept.”

They sound almost identical.

5. Objections to history being a science (Carr examines 5)

Objection 1: History deals with the unique, science with the general

Origin: Aristotle, Collingwood.

Carr's reply:

- Everything in nature is unique (no two atoms identical).
- Yet science still generalizes.
- History also generalizes:

Examples:

- Both Peloponnesian War and World War II = “wars”
- Constantine's Christianity & rise of Islam = “revolutions”

Historians always generalize:

- Causes of World War I
- Patterns of revolutions
- Whether Richard III killed the princes (based on typical royal behavior)

Conclusion:

| History studies the general **within** the unique.

Marx's famous statement:

| Similar events in different contexts produce different results; no universal master-key explains history.

6. History and sociology

Sociology risks:

1. Becoming too abstract
2. Becoming mere statistics

Carr says:

- Both history and sociology must study **social change**
- Both balance:
 - Unique events
 - General patterns

| The more sociological history becomes and the more historical sociology becomes, the better for both.

7. Does history teach lessons?

Some say: history teaches nothing.

Carr strongly disagrees.

Example:

At the 1919 Paris Peace Conference:

They used lessons from:

- Congress of Vienna

Lessons included:

- Respect self-determination
- Don't discard secret documents carelessly

These lessons influenced decisions.

Other examples:

- Rome learning from Greece
- Puritans learning from Old Testament
- British empire learning from Rome
- Russian revolutionaries learning from the French Revolution

But:

| We learn about the past through the present and about the present through the past.

History = mutual illumination.

8. Can history predict the future?

Critics say:

- Science predicts
- History cannot

Carr replies:

Even science:

- Predicts only **tendencies**, not specific events
- Works in probabilities

Example:

- You can predict measles will spread
- You cannot predict which child will get it

Same in history:

- Cannot predict "revolution next month"
- But can say conditions make revolution **likely**

Thus:

History provides general guides for action, not precise forecasts.

9. Subject and object problem (historian studies humans)

This is the strongest difference from natural science.

In history:

- Observer (historian)
- Object (human beings)

belong to the **same category**.

Therefore:

- Historian's viewpoint affects facts
- Society affects historian
- Historian's analysis affects society

Examples:

- Bolsheviks feared a Napoleon → mistrusted Trotsky, trusted Stalin
- Economists predicting recession may cause one
- Politicians predict victory to make it happen

Thus:

Interaction between historian and facts is continuous.

Modern physics also questions strict separation of subject and object, but Carr warns not to rely too much on analogy.

Key conclusion:

Social sciences cannot fit any theory of knowledge that rigidly separates subject and object.

10. Religion and history

Carr's position:

- A historian may believe God gave history meaning as a whole
- But cannot use God to explain particular events

Rejects:

- "Finger of God" explanations
- Super-historical forces like Providence or World Spirit

For history:

No "joker in the pack" (no deus ex machina).

11. Morality and private life

Historians should not judge:

- Whether Henry VIII was a good husband
- Whether Stalin was a good husband
- Whether Einstein was morally perfect

Only matters if private life affects public events.

12. Moral judgement on individuals in history (rejected)

19th-century view:

- Historian as moral judge

Examples:

- Acton
- Toynbee calling Mussolini's war a "personal sin"
- Isaiah Berlin insisting historians must judge Hitler, Napoleon, etc.

Carr rejects this.

Croce:

Past figures cannot be tried twice; historian must understand, not condemn.

13. Moral judgement on societies and institutions (accepted)

Important distinction:

Not judge individuals → judge:

- Institutions
- Systems
- Policies

Examples:

- Germans blame Hitler → avoid judging German society
- French blame Napoleon → avoid judging French Revolution
- People blame Stalin, Chamberlain, McCarthy → excuse their societies

Carr says:

- Judge slavery, not slave-owners
- Judge despotism, not individual despots

All historical interpretation involves **value judgement**.

14. The problem of suffering and “the cost of progress”

History is full of suffering.

Examples:

- Industrial Revolution:
 - Child labor
 - Slums
 - Exploitation

Yet historians accept it as **necessary cost of progress**.

Same logic applied to:

- Collectivization in USSR
- Colonialism
- Imperialism

Engels:

History drives its chariot over heaps of corpses.

Carr:

- Historian has no final answer to suffering
 - Falls back on:
 - Lesser evil
 - Greater good
-

15. No super-historical moral standard

Carr rejects:

- Divine standards
- Absolute Reason
- Eternal moral laws

Because:

- Values change with history
- Liberty, justice, equality mean different things in different eras

Moral concepts = empty cheques:

- Words printed
- Meaning filled by history

Therefore:

Abstract standards outside history are illusions.

Historians use:

- “Progressive”
- “Reactionary”

(not “good” / “evil”)

Values themselves are historical facts.

16. Final conclusion: History *is* a science (in method)

Carr’s summary:

- Science already covers many methods
- No reason to exclude history
- Exclusion comes from:
 - Old prejudice separating “humanities” and “science”

History:

- Uses hypotheses
- Generalizes
- Tests interpretations
- Revises conclusions
- Studies processes
- Makes conditional predictions
- Makes value judgments historically

Therefore:

History belongs among the sciences.

Ultra-compact exam memory sheet

- Laws → replaced by hypotheses
 - History and science both use theory + facts
 - History generalizes
 - History teaches conditional lessons
 - Predicts tendencies, not events
 - Subject and object interact
 - No God-of-the-gaps
 - Don’t judge individuals morally
 - Judge institutions & systems
 - Values are historical
 - No super-historical moral standard
 - History qualifies as a science
-

Below is a **complete, exam-oriented explanation of Chapter 3 – “History, Science, and Morality”** from E. H. Carr’s *What Is History?*, structured exactly around Carr’s arguments, examples, and conclusions. Key claims are cited directly from your attached chapter.

Chapter 3 – History, Science, and Morality (Complete Explanation)

1. Is history a science?

Carr begins with the old debate: **“Is history a science?”**

- In most European languages, *science* includes history.
- In English, history is often separated from science.

In the 18th–19th centuries:

- Science succeeded spectacularly → people tried to apply scientific methods to society and history.
- Society was first seen as a **machine** (Newtonian model).
- Later, after Darwin, as an **organism** evolving over time.

Darwin’s importance:

Science became concerned not with timeless facts, but with **process, change, and development**.

So history and science both began to focus on **change**, not static laws.

2. The old idea of “laws” in science – and why it collapsed

Earlier scientists believed:

- Nature is governed by fixed laws (Newton, Boyle, etc.).
- Scientists discover laws by induction from facts.
- Social thinkers copied this:
 - “Law of population” (Malthus)
 - “Iron law of wages” (Lassalle)
 - Marx’s “economic law of motion of modern society”

Buckle even claimed history followed “**universal and undeviating regularity.**”

But modern science changed:

Henri Poincaré showed:

- Scientific laws are really **hypotheses**
- Tools to organize thinking
- Always provisional and revisable

Modern view:

| Science progresses by a circular (better: reciprocal) process between facts and theories.

So:

- No final laws
- Only working hypotheses that help understanding

3. History uses hypotheses just like science

Carr says historians work exactly the same way.

Examples:

(a) Weber’s thesis

Protestantism → capitalism Not a law, but a **fruitful hypothesis** that deepened understanding.

(b) Marx’s example

| “The hand-mill gives feudal society; the steam-mill gives industrial capitalism.”

Again: not a law, but a guiding hypothesis.

Without hypotheses:

- Historians drown in facts (Sombart’s “ocean of facts”).

Periodization

Dividing history into:

- Ancient / Medieval / Modern

This is:

- Not a fact
- A hypothesis useful for interpretation

Same with:

- “European history”
- Whether Russia is European

These choices reveal the historian’s **bias**.

Carr quotes Georges Sorel:

| Historians must use partial, provisional hypotheses and keep correcting them.

4. History and science use the same method

Both:

- Select facts through theories
- Test theories using facts
- Advance by successive approximations

Carr notes:

A historian called history:

“a series of accepted judgements”

A physicist defined scientific truth as:

“what experts publicly accept.”

They sound almost identical.

5. Objections to history being a science (Carr examines 5)

Objection 1: History deals with the unique, science with the general

Origin: Aristotle, Collingwood.

Carr's reply:

- Everything in nature is unique (no two atoms identical).
- Yet science still generalizes.
- History also generalizes:

Examples:

- Both Peloponnesian War and World War II = “wars”
- Constantine's Christianity & rise of Islam = “revolutions”

Historians always generalize:

- Causes of World War I
- Patterns of revolutions
- Whether Richard III killed the princes (based on typical royal behavior)

Conclusion:

History studies the general **within** the unique.

Marx's famous statement:

Similar events in different contexts produce different results; no universal master-key explains history.

6. History and sociology

Sociology risks:

1. Becoming too abstract
2. Becoming mere statistics

Carr says:

- Both history and sociology must study **social change**
- Both balance:
 - Unique events
 - General patterns

The more sociological history becomes and the more historical sociology becomes, the better for both.

7. Does history teach lessons?

Some say: history teaches nothing.

Carr strongly disagrees.

Example:

At the 1919 Paris Peace Conference:

They used lessons from:

- Congress of Vienna

Lessons included:

- Respect self-determination
- Don't discard secret documents carelessly

These lessons influenced decisions.

Other examples:

- Rome learning from Greece
- Puritans learning from Old Testament
- British empire learning from Rome
- Russian revolutionaries learning from the French Revolution

But:

▮ We learn about the past through the present and about the present through the past.

History = mutual illumination.

8. Can history predict the future?

Critics say:

- Science predicts
- History cannot

Carr replies:

Even science:

- Predicts only **tendencies**, not specific events
- Works in probabilities

Example:

- You can predict measles will spread
- You cannot predict which child will get it

Same in history:

- Cannot predict "revolution next month"
- But can say conditions make revolution **likely**

Thus:

▮ History provides general guides for action, not precise forecasts.

9. Subject and object problem (historian studies humans)

This is the strongest difference from natural science.

In history:

- Observer (historian)
- Object (human beings)

belong to the **same category**.

Therefore:

- Historian's viewpoint affects facts
- Society affects historian
- Historian's analysis affects society

Examples:

- Bolsheviks feared a Napoleon → mistrusted Trotsky, trusted Stalin
- Economists predicting recession may cause one
- Politicians predict victory to make it happen

Thus:

▮ Interaction between historian and facts is continuous.

Modern physics also questions strict separation of subject and object, but Carr warns not to rely too much on analogy.

Key conclusion:

▮ Social sciences cannot fit any theory of knowledge that rigidly separates subject and object.

10. Religion and history

Carr's position:

- A historian may believe God gave history meaning as a whole
- But cannot use God to explain particular events

Rejects:

- "Finger of God" explanations
- Super-historical forces like Providence or World Spirit

For history:

No "joker in the pack" (no deus ex machina).

11. Morality and private life

Historians should not judge:

- Whether Henry VIII was a good husband
- Whether Stalin was a good husband
- Whether Einstein was morally perfect

Only matters if private life affects public events.

12. Moral judgement on individuals in history (rejected)

19th-century view:

- Historian as moral judge

Examples:

- Acton
- Toynbee calling Mussolini's war a "personal sin"
- Isaiah Berlin insisting historians must judge Hitler, Napoleon, etc.

Carr rejects this.

Croce:

Past figures cannot be tried twice; historian must understand, not condemn.

13. Moral judgement on societies and institutions (accepted)

Important distinction:

Not judge individuals → judge:

- Institutions
- Systems
- Policies

Examples:

- Germans blame Hitler → avoid judging German society
- French blame Napoleon → avoid judging French Revolution
- People blame Stalin, Chamberlain, McCarthy → excuse their societies

Carr says:

- Judge slavery, not slave-owners
- Judge despotism, not individual despots

All historical interpretation involves **value judgement**.

14. The problem of suffering and "the cost of progress"

History is full of suffering.

Examples:

- Industrial Revolution:
 - Child labor
 - Slums
 - Exploitation

Yet historians accept it as **necessary cost of progress**.

Same logic applied to:

- Collectivization in USSR
- Colonialism
- Imperialism

Engels:

History drives its chariot over heaps of corpses.

Carr:

- Historian has no final answer to suffering
- Falls back on:
 - Lesser evil
 - Greater good

15. No super-historical moral standard

Carr rejects:

- Divine standards
- Absolute Reason
- Eternal moral laws

Because:

- Values change with history
- Liberty, justice, equality mean different things in different eras

Moral concepts = empty cheques:

- Words printed
- Meaning filled by history

Therefore:

Abstract standards outside history are illusions.

Historians use:

- "Progressive"
- "Reactionary"

(not "good" / "evil")

Values themselves are historical facts.

16. Final conclusion: History *is* a science (in method)

Carr's summary:

- Science already covers many methods
- No reason to exclude history
- Exclusion comes from:
 - Old prejudice separating "humanities" and "science"

History:

- Uses hypotheses
- Generalizes
- Tests interpretations
- Revises conclusions
- Studies processes
- Makes conditional predictions
- Makes value judgments historically

Therefore:

History belongs among the sciences.

Ultra-compact exam memory sheet

- Laws → replaced by hypotheses
- History and science both use theory + facts
- History generalizes
- History teaches conditional lessons
- Predicts tendencies, not events
- Subject and object interact
- No God-of-the-gaps
- Don't judge individuals morally
- Judge institutions & systems
- Values are historical
- No super-historical moral standard
- History qualifies as a science

Below is a **complete, exam-oriented explanation of Arthur Conan Doyle's "Silver Blaze"**, covering plot, characters, themes, title significance, Holmes's reasoning, and key quotations / ideas. All factual details come from your attached text.

"Silver Blaze" – Comprehensive Explanation (for Exams)

1. Author, genre, and context

- Author: **Arthur Conan Doyle**
- Series: *The Memoirs of Sherlock Holmes*
- Genre: Detective fiction
- Setting: Dartmoor (England), Tavistock, King's Pyland and Mapleton training stables
- Narrator: **Dr. Watson**

The story is famous for one line that has become legendary in detective literature:

"The curious incident of the dog in the night-time."

2. Main characters

Sherlock Holmes

- Logical, observant, uses imagination + evidence.
- Solves the case by noticing what others ignore (silence of the dog, curry, knife, sheep).

Dr. Watson

- Narrator, medical doctor.
- Helps with the identification of the surgical knife (cataract knife).

Colonel Ross

- Owner of the racehorse **Silver Blaze**.

John Straker

- Trainer of Silver Blaze.
- Murder victim.
- Appears loyal but secretly corrupt.

Fitzroy Simpson

- Professional gambler / bookmaker.
- Main suspect arrested by police.

Inspector Gregory

- Competent but unimaginative police officer.

Silas Brown

- Trainer at Mapleton stables.
- Finds the horse and hides it.

Silver Blaze

- The racehorse.
 - Both “victim” and (ironically) the **killer**.
-

3. Plot summary (step-by-step)

A. The mystery begins

- Famous racehorse **Silver Blaze** disappears.
- His trainer **John Straker** is found dead on Dartmoor.
- Stable boy **Ned Hunter** is drugged with opium.
- Fitzroy Simpson is seen near the stables offering a bribe and later arrested.
- Evidence:
 - His cravat in Straker’s hand.
 - Heavy stick.
 - Large bets against Silver Blaze.
 - Drugged curry.

Police theory: Simpson stole the horse and murdered Straker.

B. Holmes investigates

Holmes examines:

1. **The curry with opium**
 - Opium has taste.
 - Only curry could hide it.
 - Simpson could not arrange the family’s dinner.
 - Therefore → **inside job**.
 2. **The dog that did not bark**
 - Someone entered the stable at night.
 - Dog remained silent.
 - Therefore → visitor was **someone the dog knew well**.
 3. **The knife**
 - A delicate surgical “cataract knife”.
 - Used to cut tendons, not for fighting.
 4. **The bill from a milliner**
 - Expensive women’s clothes.
 - Straker living a double life.
 - Heavy debts.
 5. **The sheep**
 - Several sheep mysteriously lame.
 - Practice for tendon-cutting.
-

C. What really happened

Holmes reconstructs the crime:

- Straker planned to **cripple Silver Blaze** by cutting its tendon.
- Motive: he had debts from a secret relationship and needed money.
- He drugged the stable boy himself.
- Took the horse out at night.
- Lit a candle to perform the operation.
- The horse was frightened.
- It kicked Straker in the head.
- Straker died from the blow.
- His knife cut his own thigh as he fell.

Thus:

▮ The horse killed Straker in self-defence.

D. What happened to Silver Blaze

- The horse ran away.

- Wandered to Mapleton stables.
- Silas Brown recognized it and hid it.
- Dyed it to disguise identity.
- Holmes blackmailed Brown into returning it secretly.

At the race:

- Horse appears with altered color.
- Wins the Wessex Cup.
- After washing, its white markings reappear.

Holmes reveals:

“The real murderer is standing immediately behind you.” (touching the horse)

4. Why Simpson looked guilty (but wasn't)

- Was bribing for information (touting).
- Dropped his cravat while fleeing.
- Was gambling heavily.
- But:
 - Could not plan the curry.
 - Had no wound.
 - Had no reason to drug stable boy.

He was **morally shady but innocent of murder**.

5. Meaning of the title – *Silver Blaze*

- Literally: the racehorse's name.
 - Symbolically:
 - Represents the truth hidden in plain sight.
 - The “silent witness” to the crime.
 - The instrument of justice.
-

6. The “curious incident of the dog”

Holmes says:

“The dog did nothing in the night-time.” “That was the curious incident.”

Meaning:

- The dog's silence proves familiarity.
- Criminal = insider (Straker).

This is one of the most famous examples of **negative evidence** in literature:

What did *not* happen is more important than what did.

7. Holmes's method of reasoning (important for exams)

Holmes uses:

1. **Negative evidence** – dog's silence
2. **Scientific reasoning** – taste of opium
3. **Psychological profiling** – debts, secret life
4. **Medical knowledge** – tendon cutting
5. **Observation** – footprints, shoes, sheep
6. **Imagination** – hypothesizing and testing
7. **Reconstruction of events**

Quote:

“We imagined what might have happened, acted upon the supposition, and found ourselves justified.”

8. Themes

1. Appearance vs Reality

- Loyal trainer → criminal
- Suspected gambler → innocent
- Missing horse → safe and victorious

2. Reason vs Assumption

- Police rely on surface evidence.
- Holmes relies on logic.

3. Betrayal of trust

- Straker betrays employer.

4. Power of observation

- Small facts → major truth.

5. Greed and moral decay

- Debt leads to crime.

9. Moral message

- Crime is often hidden behind respectability.
- Truth requires patient reasoning.
- Justice may come indirectly.

10. Important exam points to remember

- Murderer: **Silver Blaze (accidentally)**
- Criminal planner: **John Straker**
- Key clue: **dog's silence + curry + knife + sheep**
- Holmes clears Simpson
- Horse wins race
- Police theory is wrong

11. One-page exam revision summary

Problem: Horse disappears, trainer dead. **Suspect:** Simpson (false). **Clues:**

- Drugged curry
- Silent dog
- Surgical knife
- Lamé sheep
- Expensive bills

Truth: Straker planned to injure horse → horse killed him → horse escaped → hidden by Brown → Holmes recovers it → wins race.

Famous line: "The curious incident of the dog in the night-time."
